Digvijaya Singh, the senior Congress leader, was a very worried man. Like many Congressmen, he could see the writing on the wall. But unlike several Congress leaders, at least he had relatively direct access to Rahul. Digvijaya had, so far, been against the idea of making this election Rahul versus Modi. Now, he felt that it was important that the young Gandhi at least send out a message to the party cadres that he was ready to lead. 'The workers need to be energized, Rahulji, they need you to give them a sense of direction, a feeling that we can win this election. You need to lead us from the front,' he said. Rahul nodded attentively. 'Yes, yes, I know, Digivjayaji. When the time comes, we will be ready!'

But time was running out. The AICC session was scheduled for 17 January at Talkatora Stadium in the capital. Hundreds of party delegates from across India had gathered to listen to their leadership. Manmohan Singh, who had just announced his retirement from politics, spoke in the morning. Sonia Gandhi had also spoken before lunch. The crowd, though, was getting restive. *'Rahul Gandhi aage badho, hum tumhare saath hai'* (Come forward, we are with you), was the predictable chant. A resolution was passed that the party would fight the 2014 elections under his leadership.

Rahul finally spoke around 3.30 p.m. A year earlier, he had addressed a similar conclave in Jaipur and delivered his famous 'power is poison' speech. This time, there could be no emotional message of self-renunciation. The party was looking to win an election and needed their leader to take the battle to the enemy. For once, Rahul did not let them down.

In an hour-long speech that alternated between Hindi and English, Rahul displayed an aggression which had been missing so far. He repeatedly targeted Narendra Modi, without naming him. The one-liners came thick and fast: 'Democracy is not rule by one man; democracy is rule by the elected representatives of the people'; 'The Opposition are very good marketeers, they sing, they dance, they can sell combs to the bald. Do not be swayed by their big talk.'